

The Age Structure of the Electorate

Who is old enough to vote, who says they voted, and sixty years of the gap between the two

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“The electorate” is a phrase that does two jobs and hides the difference. It sometimes means everybody entitled to vote, and it sometimes means everybody who did. Those are different populations, and the clearest way to see how different is to draw them as two pyramids on one axis.

In 2024, **260.4m** Americans were old enough to vote and **154.4m** told the Census Bureau they had — 59.3%. The people in the second group are not a scale model of the first. They are older, and they have been getting relatively older for sixty years.

01 One row is a year and an age band

Age band	Old enough to vote	Said they voted	Turnout	Registered
18–24	30.0m	13.2m	43.9%	53.5%
25–44	88.8m	46.5m	52.4%	61.5%
45–64	81.2m	51.3m	63.2%	69.8%
65+	60.4m	43.3m	71.7%	77.1%

Column	What it holds	Measurement
year	the federal election year, 1966 to 2024	discrete
band	one of the Bureau’s four age bands	ordered categorical
vap	voting-age population, in thousands	count
pct_voted	the share who told the survey they voted	continuous
voters	vap multiplied by that share — a count this chapter derives	count

The Bureau publishes the population and the percentage; the count of voters is the two multiplied, which is arithmetic on its own figures rather than an estimate of ours. The four bands are published separately from the total, so they can be checked against it:

Check	Value
age blocks found	10
years covered	30
largest gap, bands against total (population)	0.001%
largest gap, bands against total (voters)	0.207%

Before you read on, commit to a view. People aged 65 and over are 23.2% of American adults. **What share of the votes do you think they cast?** Write it down, and write down what you would have guessed for 1968.

02 Two pyramids

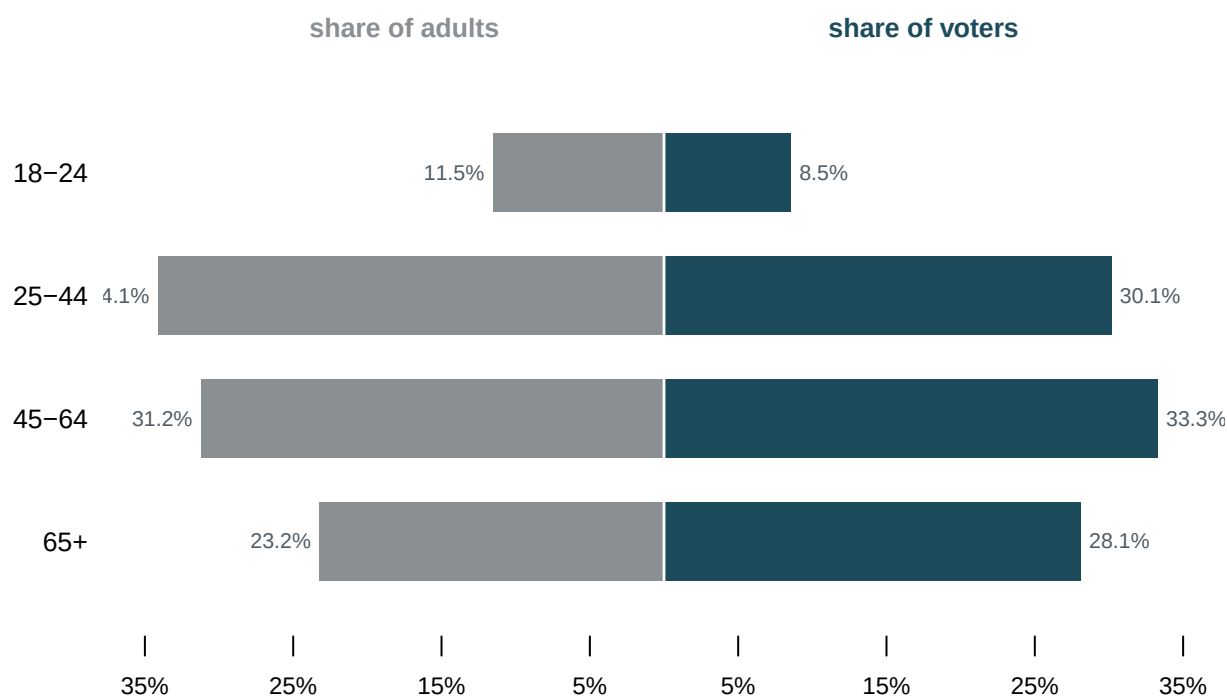


Figure 1. The adult population and the voters, 2024. Bands are the four the Census Bureau publishes. Grey to the left is each band's share of everybody old enough to vote; teal to the right is its share of everybody who said they voted. Drag the year; the button switches from shares to counts of people.

The two sides are not the same shape. **People aged 65 and over are 23.2% of the adult population and 28.1% of the voters.** People aged 18 to 24 are 11.5% of adults and 8.5% of voters. Compare that with what you wrote down.

The mechanism is not mysterious — it is turnout. 71.7% of the oldest band said they voted against 43.9% of the youngest, a ratio of 1.6 to one. Some of that gap opens before the ballot: 77.1% of the oldest band were registered against 53.5% of the youngest, so roughly half the difference is a registration difference rather than a turnout one.

03 The gap is not a constant

Now drag Figure 1 back to the 1960s, or read it here.

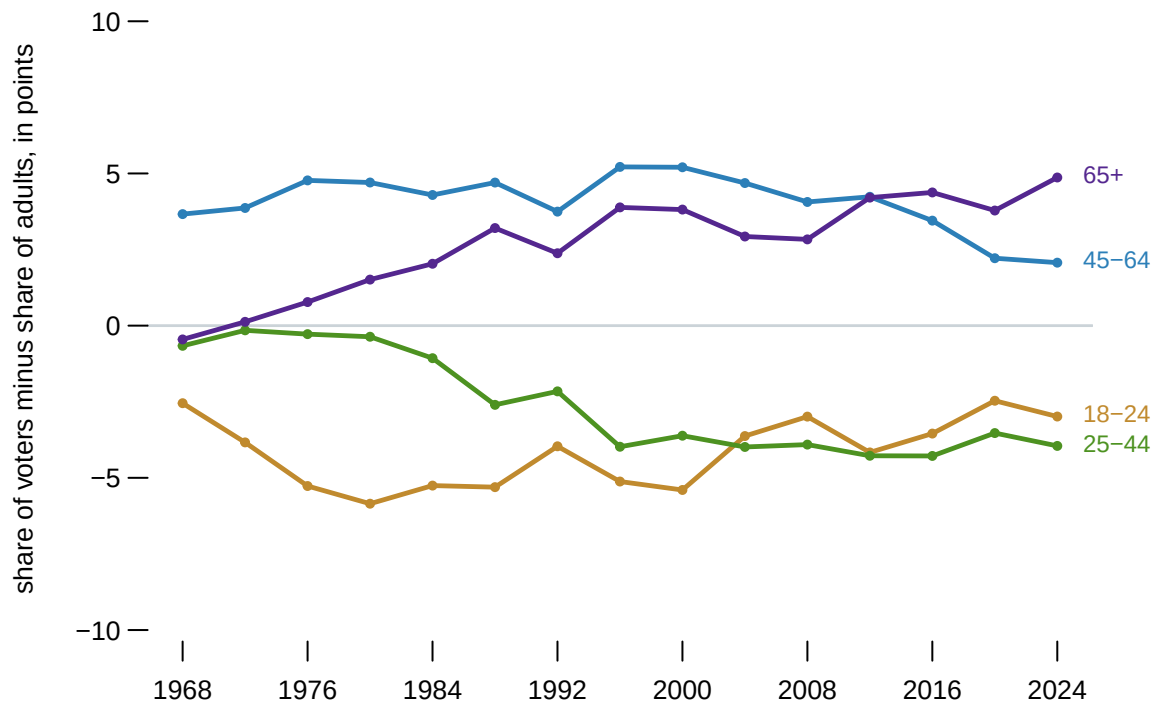


Figure 2. Over-representation, presidential elections 1968 to 2024. Zero means a band cast exactly its share of the votes. Above the line it is over-represented among voters; below it, under-represented.

The oldest band starts at **-0.5** in 1968, meaning it voted almost exactly in proportion to its size. It ends at **+4.9**. That is the finding, and it is not the one most people expect. The over-representation of older voters is not an old feature of American elections. It is roughly as old as the people currently complaining about it.

Two things drove it and they are easy to confuse. The band grew: 65-and-over went from 15.8% of adults in 1968 to 23.2% now, which is demography and would have raised their share of the votes even if nothing about their behaviour had changed. And on top of that their turnout advantage widened. **The first is a fact about the country. The second is a fact about its politics.** A figure of votes cast alone cannot separate them, which is why this one is drawn as a difference between two shares rather than as a count.

The youngest band, meanwhile, is roughly where it was. It has been between -8.9 and -2.5 points under-represented in every presidential election in the series. Whatever has changed about young Americans and voting, their standing relative to their own numbers is not it.

A second prediction. Suppose turnout rose by ten points in every age band at once. **What would happen to the lines in Figure 2?** Answer before you read the next paragraph.

Nothing would happen to them. A uniform rise cancels out in a share. That is what makes Figure 2 readable, and it is also what makes it blind. It cannot tell you whether an elec-

tion was high-turnout or low, only who was over-represented within it. Figure 1's counts button is there for that.

04 What this chapter cannot tell you

These are people who said they voted. The Current Population Survey asks, after the election, and nobody checks. The validated-turnout chapter establishes that the answer is consistently too high — in 2024 the survey implies more voters than there were ballots. If over-reporting differs by age, and there is good reason to think it does, then the right-hand pyramid is distorted in a way none of these figures can correct. **Every “voter” in this chapter is a survey respondent’s claim.**

Four bands is a coarse pyramid. A conventional population pyramid has five-year bands and splits by sex; this one has four unequal bands and no sex, because that is what the historical table publishes. The 25-to-44 band spans twenty years and the 65-and-over band has no upper bound, so both hide structure — the oldest band in particular mixes people at very different turnout rates.

Nothing here is about a state. These are national figures. The turnout-denominator chapter shows how much states differ on the denominator alone, the bottom number a turnout rate is divided by. An age pyramid for Florida would not look like one for Utah.

Being over-represented is not the same as being decisive. A band that casts 28.1% of the votes decides nothing on its own, and this chapter has said nothing about how any band voted. It is a chapter about who shows up, and who shows up is prior to, and separate from, what they do when they get there.

05 Sources

- U.S. Census Bureau. *Current Population Survey, Voting and Registration Supplement*, Table A-1, historical time series, November 1964 to 2024. https://www2.census.gov/programs-surveys/cps/tables/time-series/voting-historical-time-series/hst_vote01.xlsx
- The same workbook is read for its national totals by this corpus’s validated-turnout chapter, which documents what the table does and does not publish. The four age blocks further down the same sheet are read here, and checked to see that they re-construct the published total.

The data itself

Every figure above is drawn from these tables. They are plain CSV, they open in a spreadsheet, and they are yours to take further.

`bands.csv`, `shares.csv`

Your turn

None of these is answered above, and every one can be answered from the tables you just opened.

- `shares.csv` carries a gap for every year and age band: the share of the population set against the share of the voters. Which band’s gap has closed the most across the series, and which has barely moved?

- `bands.csv` reports `pct_registered` and `pct_voted` separately. Work out what share of the registered actually voted, band by band. Do the youngest fail to register, or fail to turn out?
- Pick a presidential year in `bands.csv` and the midterm beside it. Which age band falls away the most between the two?
- Everything here is people saying they voted, not records of them voting. Add up voters across the bands and set it against a turnout figure from anywhere else. Which way does the error run?

REBUILD THIS DATA YOURSELF, WITH AN AI ASSISTANT

I want to rebuild a public dataset from its original source, without any starting files. Please do the following and show your work.

THE SOURCE. U.S. Census Bureau, Current Population Survey, Voting and Registration Supplement, historical Table A-1. One spreadsheet at https://www2.census.gov/programs-surveys/cps/tables/time-series/voting-historical-time-series/hst_vote01.xlsx

No account or key is needed. The sheet is not one table: it is ten tables stacked in a single column. Five age groups – the total, then 18 to 24, 25 to 44, 45 to 64, and 65 and over – each appear twice, once under a heading ending "Percent Voted" and once under "Percent Registered". Find those headings and read years downward until the years stop. Populations are in thousands. And keep in mind what this is: a survey that asks people after the election whether they voted, and nobody checks. People say yes more often than they voted.

WHAT TO BUILD.

1. One table with a row per election year per age group: the voting-age population, the percent who said they voted, and the count of voters that implies.
2. Each group's share of all adults beside its share of everyone who said they voted, year by year – two age pyramids, one of the population and one of the reported electorate.

CHECK YOUR WORK. The copy this book used was fetched in August 2026.

If your rebuild matches it, you should find:

- ten stacked tables, together covering 30 federal elections from 1966 through 2024
- in 2024, an adult population of 260,363 thousand, of whom 154,395 thousand said they voted

- in 2024, 43.9% of 18-to-24-year-olds said they voted, against 71.7% of people 65 and over
- the four age groups reconstruct the published total to within 0.207%

The Bureau extends this workbook after each federal election; a later final year means the series grew, not that you made an error.